How I Built a Winning Power BI Report

And how you can, too!



ONYX DATA CHALLENGE WINNER

170+ entries submitted

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1. Modern reports aren't just about numbers - they're about *narrative*

Creating a narrative turns your report from a static data wall into a guided experience. So how do you create a narrative? Here are some ideas:

1 Set the Scene: What Question is the Report Answering?

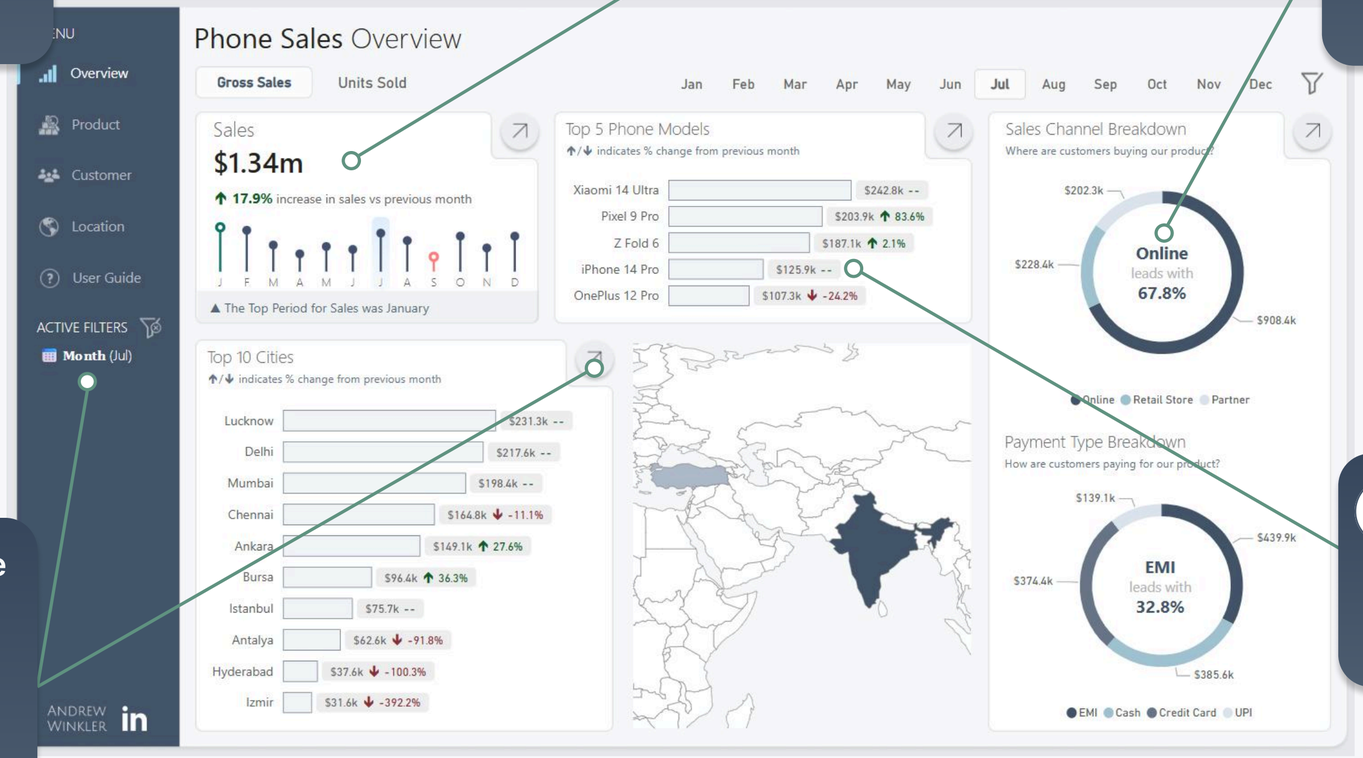
"Which cities and models are driving sales - and are we improving month-over-month?

2 Lead with the Outcome (Then Let Them Explore Why)

I immediately show $1.34m in sales with a clear visual performance indicator: that's the climax

3 Micro-Stories in Components

Each visual tells a **mini story** for additional insight



4 Call Attention to What Changed

Show change *visually* with icons and colors

5 Filters and Bookmarks: Create a Guided Experience

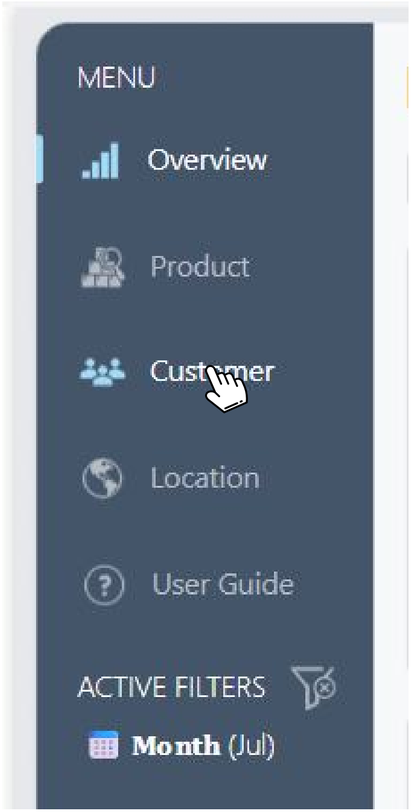
Build an interactive tour of the data. Show active filters, and provide navigation throughout the report easily and intuitively

2. Modern reports should feel like apps

Good design means users already know how to use it — because it works like everything else they trust!

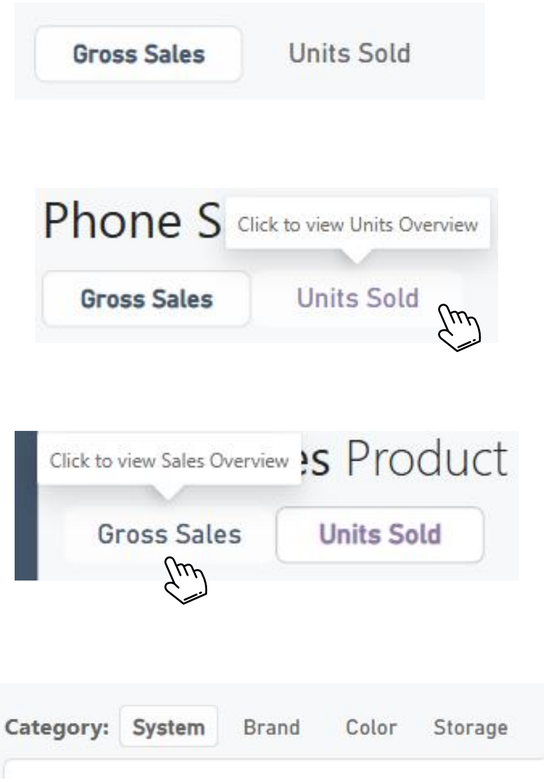
1 Web-App Style Sidebars

This mimics what users expect from web apps like Google Analytics, Figma, Salesforce, etc



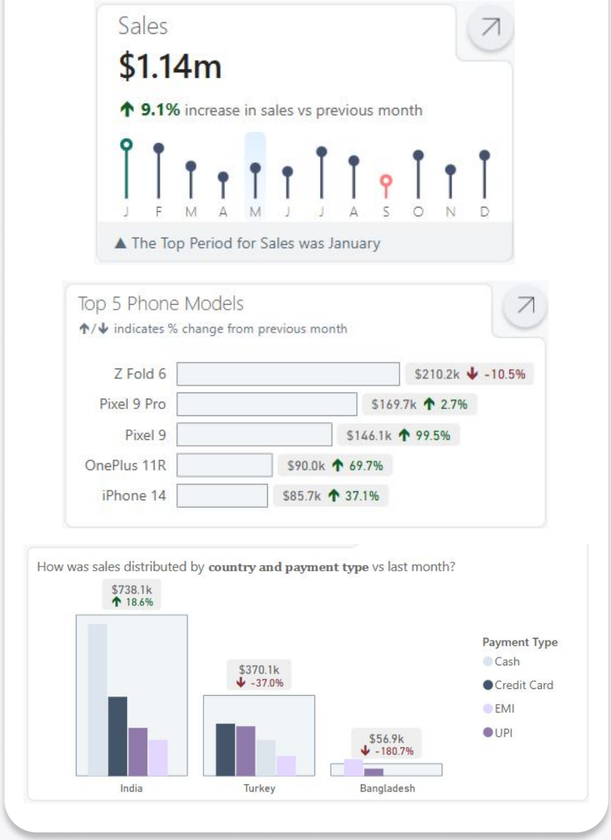
2 Use Tabs/Buttons for Navigation & Slicers

Use visual cues like active/ inactive styles, and hover effects



3 Clear Callouts & Highlight Colors

Use green for increases, red for decreases, and neutral for no change



4 Use a Clean and Minimalistic Design and Layout

Clean lines, ample white space, clear typography, and only a few different colors



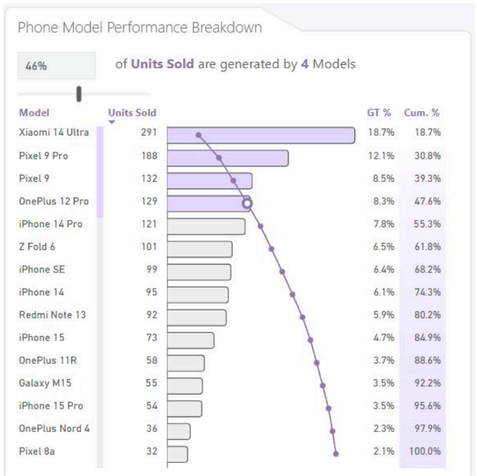
3. Take your report to the next level with custom visuals

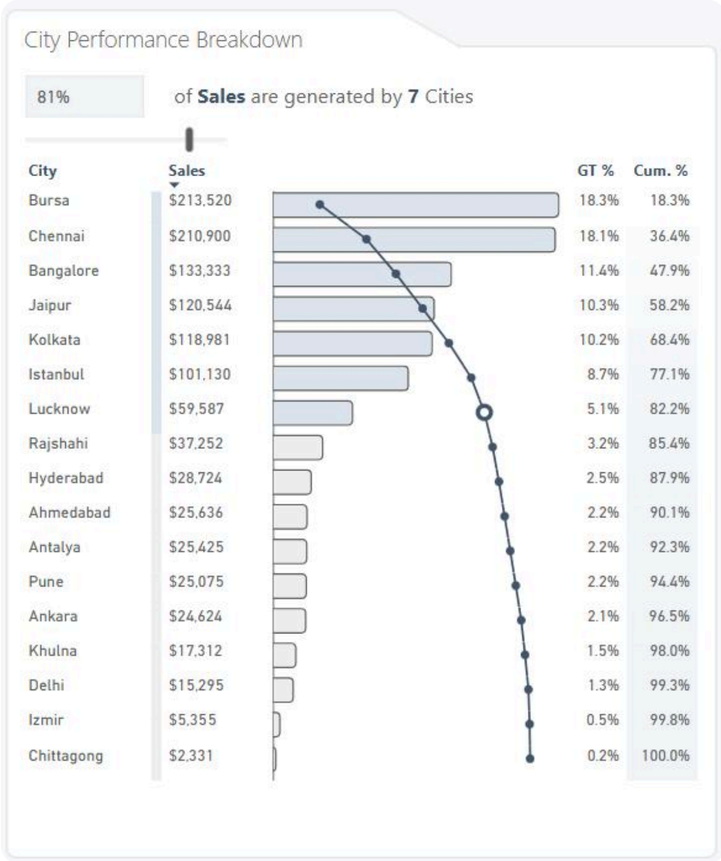
Create tailored visuals by mixing native charts, field parameters, SVG, and custom tools like Deneb, Python, or R

1 SVGs for Embedded Charts in Cards and Matrix Visuals

Use SVG with DAX to build visuals like sparklines and Pareto charts directly in cards or matrix tables. Just make sure they add clarity or insight—not just decoration. Bonus: subtle animation can guide attention and boost engagement.







2 Use Native Visuals, Parameters, and Bookmarks to Create a Custom Experience

Empower users to choose how they view the data by blending field parameters, bookmarks, and core Power BI visuals—making the report feel more interactive and tailored.

